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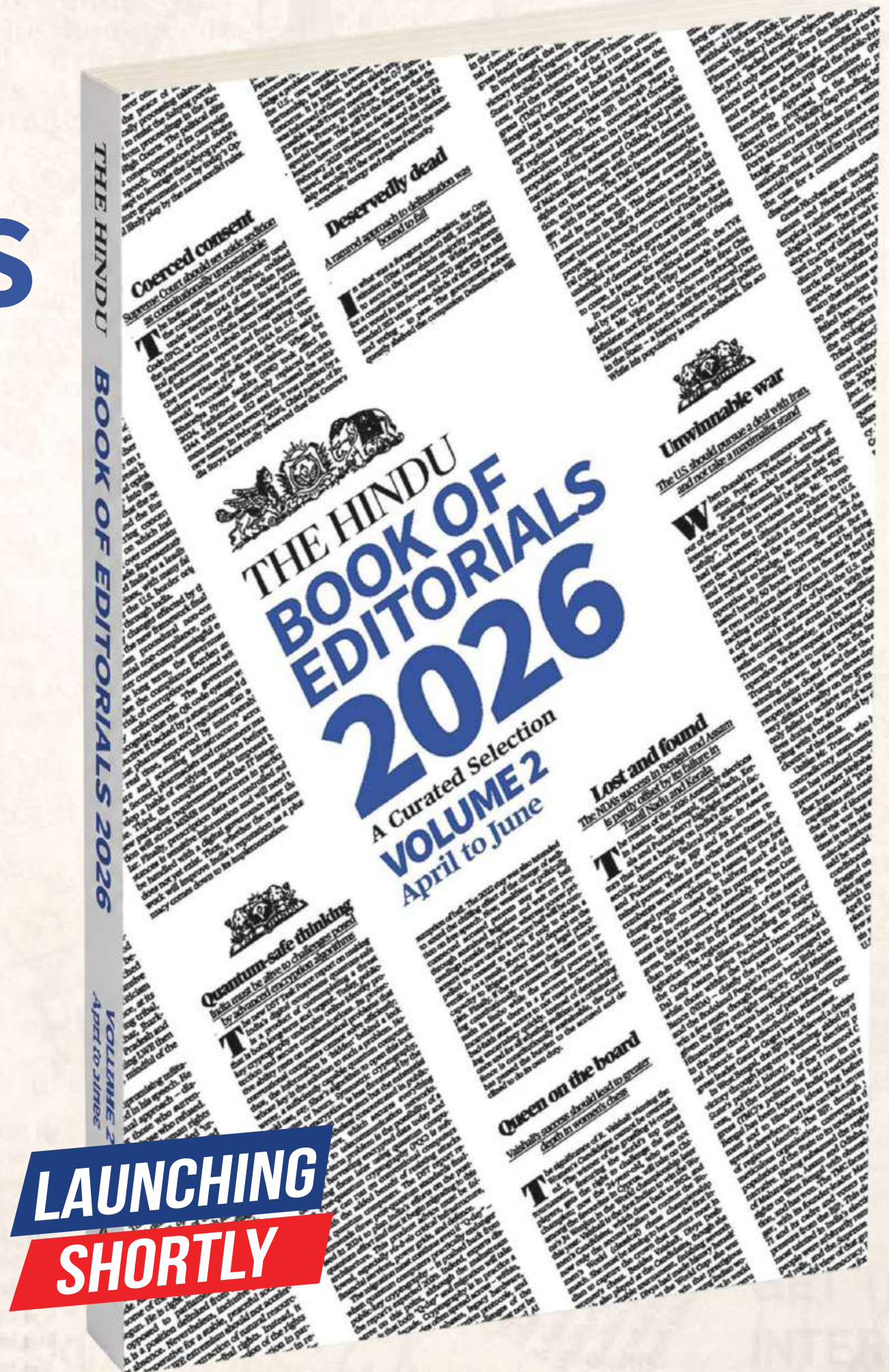
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PANEL FOR DEMANDS

Bank unions defer 3-day strike after talks with IBA

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EURASIAN OPPORTUNITIES

Kashmir as India's gateway

Reconnecting the Valley's historic routes could unlock its potential, writes Mehbooba

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CHESS OLYMPIAD

Indian men win silver, women claim bronze

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EC steps won't undo 'mass disenfranchisement': Cong.

Poll panel's proposed measures amount to an admission that the SIR exercise has been a 'disaster', says Congress leader; targeted removal of marginalised voters meant to benefit the BJP, he adds

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A day after the Election Commission announced multiple steps to address concerns about the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the Congress on Sunday termed them a "desperate attempt at damage control" that "hides all and reveals nothing".

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said the proposed measures amounted to an admission that the exercise had been a "disaster", warning that the "piecemeal" steps would do little to mitigate what he called "mass disenfranchisement".

He questioned several of the assurances given by



Congress workers take out a demonstration in Kolkata on Saturday demanding the suspension of the SIR. AP

the EC, including its proposal to review the ECINet software and plan for booth-level officers to visit the electors who received notices. "We know that in practice these visits were sparse and sporadic. What is the value of promising a second round of visits which likely will not hap-

pen? The logic of repeating a process done poorly once must be examined," he said.

Questioning the rationale of the entire SIR process, which he described as a "colossal waste" of resources, Mr. Ramesh said that nearly 14 crore voters whose names were deleted

Over 2,000 citizens write to CJI against EC

NEW DELHI

Over 2,000 citizens across the country have signed an open letter to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, urging him to initiate suo motu proceedings against the conduct of the Election Commission regarding the SIR and the deployment of the ECINet software. » PAGE 11

from the rolls were now being asked to apply afresh for inclusion. The targeted removal of marginalised voters was meant to benefit the BJP, he said.

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5 'terrorists' held near U.K. base used by U.S.

Agence France-Presse
FAIRFORD

British counter-terrorism forces were probing "a major incident" near a base used by the U.S. Air Force in its war against Iran after arresting five men on suspicion of "preparing a terrorist act", the police said on Sunday.

Armed officers detained the group in the early hours after a call to emergency services about three "suspicious vehicles which appeared to be travelling towards the air base", London's Metropolitan Police said in a statement.

U.S. President Donald Trump said that the suspects were aiming at doing significant damage to the base. "We had them under investigation... they were looking to do big damage to our fort, and working with the British worked out great," he told presspersons. "We had them under view for a long time, and we got them," he added.



A U.S. B-1B Lancer bomber on the tarmac of the Fairford air base on Sunday. REUTERS

The suspects were initially held near the Royal Air Force Fairford air base in Gloucestershire on suspicion of carrying explosives. Some 85 households in the nearby village of Whelford were advised to evacuate and army bomb disposal experts were called in.

Prime Minister Andy Burnham was being kept updated on the incident, a British government spokesperson said.

CONTINUED ON

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IN BRIEF

Parvesh slaps AAP MLA's aide; Oppn. hits out at BJP

NEW DELHI

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh was allegedly caught on camera slapping an aide of AAP Tilak Nagar MLA Jarnail Singh during a road inspection in west Delhi's Tilak Nagar on Sunday. The incident prompted sharp reactions from the Opposition while the Minister claimed that AAP workers had abused him and his family. » Page 2



EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 5

Joy unbound



Ecstatic: Ancy Sojan is over the moon after winning the silver medal in the women's long jump at the Asian Games on Sunday. Sarvesh Kushare (high jump), Anahat Singh, and Abhay Singh (squash) too won silver medals on Sunday. R.V. MOORTHY (REPORT: PAGE 15)

Iran stands firm on plan for reopening Hormuz Strait

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON/TEHRAN

Iran stood firm on Sunday on its conditions for reopening the Strait of Hormuz, despite U.S. President Donald Trump's rejection of the proposal, leaving the war in West Asia locked in a stalemate.

"Our conditions are clear, and any move toward reopening the Strait of Hormuz is contingent upon these conditions being fulfilled. We will not back down from them," Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said.

FULL REPORT ON

» PAGE 14

T.N. rescinds G.O. exempting Public Dept. from RTI Act

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

After facing severe backlash from political parties and activists, the Tamil Nadu government on Sunday decided to withdraw a controversial order exempting the Public (Law and Order) Department from the ambit of the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005, on the ground that it was an intelligence and security organisation.

A Government Order (dated September 21, 2026) to this effect was issued by the Human Resources Management Department under Section 24(4) of the RTI Act and then notified in the Government Gazette.

Minister for Energy Resources and Law C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar wrote on X that the G.O. had been withdrawn. Speaking to reporters earlier in the day in Madurai, he had defended the order, saying that only certain provisions, including details of communal clashes, were kept out of the ambit of the RTI Act, given the sensitivity of the information.

Opposition to order

Earlier, AMMK founder T.T.V. Dhinakaran, environmental activist G. Sundarajan of Poovulagin Nambargal, and Arappor Iyakkam convenor Jayaram Venkatesan opposed the G.O.

The Public (Law and Order) Department deals with subjects such as communal and caste clashes; the appointment of Commissions of Inquiry into law and order matters and follow-up action on their

The G.O., issued by the Department of Human Resources Management, drew severe backlash from political parties and activists

recommendations; all matters relating to COFEPOSA and NSA detentions, including representations by detenus and habeas corpus petitions filed by detenus or on their behalf in the High Court and the Supreme Court; and the conduct of monthly law and order review meetings and special law and order meetings under the instructions of the Chief Secretary.

G.O.'s ambit

It also includes examining inquiry reports into the opening of fire by the police and inquiry reports into deaths in police custody, police torture and deaths of remand prisoners; NHRC references relating to matters dealt with by the law and order wing; furnishing monthly reports on law and order and communal incidents to the Government of India; furnishing replies to Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha questions relating to law and order matters; dealing with agitations by students, agricultural labourers and political parties; requests for withdrawal of cases registered on political grounds, communal/caste clashes, political agitations and student agitations; and matters relating to sanction of prosecution for defamatory articles, news items and speeches.

Protests erupt over Punjab 'campus rape'

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

Allegations that a student was raped on the campus of Lovely Professional University (LPU) in Punjab sparked an agitation that led to protesters, mainly students, blocking National Highway-44 near Phagwara on Sunday.

The stir, which took place hours after the protesters went on a rampage and vandalised university property, disrupted traffic and led to clashes with the police.

The police registered a first information report (FIR) containing rape charges against unknown persons and a special investigation team has been constituted to probe the



Protesters block the National Highway near LPU campus in Punjab on Sunday. PTI

matter. The students have alleged that a female hostel had been raped by a plumber three days ago and claimed that no action had been taken in the matter so far. LPU, a private institute, has denied the allegations.

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25 km in raging river amid crocodiles, the longest night for 75-year-old Odisha woman

Septuagenarian from Jajpur survives 12 hours in the swollen Brahmani river after falling into it at night; she braves strong floodwaters before being rescued from a neighbouring district on Sunday

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

For more than 12 hours in pitch darkness, Keshi Dalai, 75, clung to life as the raging Brahmani river in Odisha carried her through swollen floodwaters for nearly 25 km.

With crocodiles lurking in the turbulent waters and the river showing no mercy, every passing minute brought her closer to death. Yet, against all odds, the septuagenarian survived the ordeal and was rescued alive on



Keshi Dalai after her rescue in Kendrapara of Odisha on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Sunday morning. Ms. Dalai, a resident of Kalakhanda, a riverside village in Jajpur district, had gone to the riverbank to relieve herself late on Saturday evening while her family was asleep. She

was swept away by the Brahmani river, which was in spate following heavy rain, after she lost her balance.

The stretch of the Brahmani where she fell in is known for its crocodiles. Residents have erected barricades in the water at several places for protection. More than 20 people have been dragged into the river by crocodiles over the past five years. Against this backdrop, Ms. Dalai's survival through the dead of night is being hailed as nothing short of a miracle.

Throughout the night,

Ms. Dalai managed to remain afloat. On Sunday morning, she was spotted waving for help and was rescued by a group of youth at Balipatna village in Kendrapara district – at a distance of 25 km by river course and 45 km by road from her village. "In the morning, we could not find her. As the search continued, a call from the Pattamundai police in Kendrapara brought us immense relief," said Aranya Dalai, Ms. Dalai's son-in-law.

CONTINUED ON
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Padmakumar Nair

Few topics in higher education receive as much attention as industry-academia collaboration. Every policy document, accreditation framework, and university strategy seems to ask the same question: What must universities do differently to become more relevant to industry?

How practical is it?
While it is an important question, I increasingly wonder whether we have been asking the wrong one. Over the years, we have created an idealised picture of university-industry collaboration.

Every student should complete a meaningful internship. Every professor should work on industry-sponsored research. Universities and companies should jointly develop products, technologies, and services. Graduates should seamlessly transition into employment. It is an inspiring vision, but is it practical?

According to the All-India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE), India produces around one crore graduates every year. But the country generates only about 10 to 15 lakh entry-level graduate jobs annually. The economy, undoubtedly, creates many more jobs, but relatively few are high-skilled positions requiring a university degree.

This mismatch fundamentally changes the discussion. Even if every company genuinely wanted to

The collaboration conundrum

Are industry-academia partnerships practical or a romantic dream?



collaborate with universities, can industry realistically provide quality internships for millions of students every year? Can companies dedicate engineers, managers, scientists, and designers to mentor such numbers? Can every faculty member undertake industry-funded research? Can every university sustain advanced laboratories capable of supporting collaborative product development? Meaningful collaboration depends on several

important preconditions. Students must possess sufficient technical competence before entering the industry.

Capacity matters
Companies must have the organisational bandwidth to supervise interns and collaborative projects. Faculty members must be engaged in high-quality research that industry finds valuable. Universities must possess research infrastructure, labs, and administrative systems capable

of supporting sustained partnerships. Internationally, countries such as Germany, Japan, South Korea, and several European nations have built stronger university-industry ecosystems that evolved through decades of sustained industrial development, strong research universities, and carefully designed public policies. Even the U.S., often regarded as the benchmark for innovation, does not achieve the universal mo-

del of industry-academia collaboration that many discussions implicitly assume. Outstanding partnerships are concentrated in particular universities, industries, and research-intensive institutions rather than being the norm across the entire higher education system.

Questions to ask
Perhaps, then, the issue is not that universities are underperforming but that our expectations are unrealistic. This suggests that it is time to ask: What exactly are we trying to achieve? Is the primary objective employability, innovation, technology transfer, entrepreneurship, regional economic development, or workforce readiness?

Different goals require different models of collaboration. A single framework cannot serve every discipline or institution. The second question is how we incentivise companies to collaborate with universities. Industry cannot be expected to collaborate simply because policymakers encourage it. Companies invest time and resources when they perceive clear value, whether through access to talent, cutting-edge research, intellectual property, or long-term competitiveness.

Finally, the most practical question of all: if deep industry collaboration cannot realistically reach every student, how should universities prepare graduates for successful careers? Perhaps the answer

lies less in attempting to replicate industry inside the university and more in developing graduates who can learn quickly after entering the workforce.

The future belongs to graduates who possess strong analytical ability, excellent communication skills, teamwork, intellectual humility, ethical judgement, and the capacity for lifelong learning. Technical knowledge will matter, but the ability to continuously acquire new knowledge may matter even more.

Industry-academia collaboration should certainly be expanded wherever it creates genuine value. It remains indispensable for research-intensive universities, innovation ecosystems, and technology-driven sectors. However, it should not become the sole measure of educational quality or institutional success.

The future of higher education will depend not merely on increasing the quantity of collaboration between universities and industry, but on designing

models that are realistic, scalable, and aligned with the needs of both.

Perhaps the time has come to stop asking how universities can become more like industry and, instead, ask a more fundamental question: What kind of graduates does society need, and what is the most practical way to prepare them?

Views expressed are personal

The writer is Vice Chancellor, Thapar Institute of Engineering and Technology.

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India's institutions have largely held, except in dark periods such as the Emergency, when an executive emboldened by legislative strength ran roughshod over the Constitution and a shamelessly permissive judiciary let it do so via *ADM Jabalpur*. The ECI under Mr. Kumar has overseen the removal of more than 13 crore names from draft rolls through the SIR which, as this daily has repeatedly argued, shifts the onus of enrolment from the state to the elector, deletes names before it verifies and imposes onerous conditions for re-entry. It got away with this because the Supreme Court declined for months to decide whether the exercise was constitutional. When it finally ruled on May 27, the SIR was already a settled fact in Bihar, West Bengal and other Phase 2 States. The judgment, reminiscent of *ADM Jabalpur*'s deference to the state, engaged the SIR in theory and not in practice. It read a provision for exceptional, targeted revisions as a licence for a State-wide sweep. While it assured voters already on the rolls that they were still presumed eligible, the SIR made them prove it all over again. And it brushed aside its 1995 ruling that every removal must be individually reasoned. Events since then indicate the damage done – over nine in 10 appeals decided by West Bengal's tribunals have restored deleted voters' names after the Assembly polls; and in one third of Delhi's seats, the draft rolls have fewer electors than those who voted in 2025. The ECI's press note changes very little. The ECI must be reconstituted by a selection committee that does not give the government an overriding majority. Anything less would be a travesty of institutional democracy.

As the U.S. and China recalibrate ties, implications for other nations are huge

The modest outcomes from the Xi visit should not obscure the broader shift that recent U.S.-China engagement has underlined. The agreement between the world's two biggest powers to pursue what they call a constructive relationship of strategic stability based on fairness, respect and reciprocity points to a new equilibrium. Their relationship certainly remains beset by serious structural challenges and will remain one marked by rivalry. At the same time, both sides appear eager to set a floor to ensure a rivalry that is more managed, stable and predictable. Countries in the region will be watching closely how this may temper an "America First" Washington's appetite to push back against China in waters far from home. New Delhi will need to carefully watch this evolving new equilibrium. The recent U.S. tariff threats aimed at India have offered a stark contrast to the measured language with which Washington has been engaging Beijing. For long, a strand of Indian strategic thinking has been predicated on the assumption that U.S. strategy in the region was centred on the idea of a relationship with India as a bulwark against Chinese influence. That assumption increasingly appears open to question.

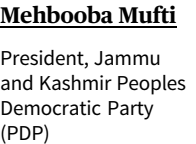
The aspiration-reality gap

The smartphone revolution has intensified this challenge. A young person in a town or remote village can now see within seconds how the rest of the world lives, studies, works and travels. Global possibilities are visible on high-definition screens, even as tangible opportunities remain painfully out of reach.

This has created a widening divide between aspiration and reality. The horizons of young Indians have expanded far faster than the institutions and economies around them. Access to higher education has widened, yet meaningful employment opportunities have not kept pace. A college degree is no longer a guarantee of a job, leaving many without financial security or the dignity that comes with economic independence. When heightened aspirations collide with limited opportunities, frustration inevitably follows, often finding expression in protests over recruitment, examination irregularities, examination and test paper leaks, unemployment and systemic failures.

Kashmiri youth share these aspirations but carry a compounding historical burden. Decades of conflict, political uncertainty and economic isolation have deepened their sense of insecurity and constrained their opportunities. Too often, young Kashmiris have been viewed through a narrow security lens, as potential liabilities rather than national assets.

Yet, Jammu and Kashmir, like the rest of India, has a large young population with its own aspirations. Its youth seek the same basic things as young people elsewhere: economic



Reconnecting Kashmir's historic routes could unlock economic opportunities for its youth

Focus on Kashmir's historic crossroads

For centuries, Kashmir was never a cul-de-sac. It was a thriving crossroads. Historic caravan routes linked Kashmir and Ladakh with Central Asia, Tibet and the broader Indian subcontinent. These routes carried far more than merchandise. They connected people, ideas, philosophies, literature, cultures and skills. The arrival of Mir Sayyid Ali Hamadani, revered as Shah-i-Hamadani, is deeply embedded in Kashmiri history and is traditionally associated with the arrival of Persian and Central Asian craftsmen who enriched Kashmir's celebrated handicraft traditions. The historical lesson is clear: connectivity creates economic ecosystems.

Today, Indian strategic thinking needs to look beyond the immediate constraints posed by the Line of Control with Pakistan and the Line of Actual Control with China. Where political and security conditions permit, India needs a pragmatic framework to gradually restore Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh to the role they historically occupied: that of a bridge connecting South Asia with Central Asia and the wider Eurasian landmass.

For this, India needs a diplomatic road map alongside its infrastructure road map. Reopening traditional routes towards Pakistan or Central Asia cannot happen without sustained engagement with neighbouring countries. With Pakistan, the objective should be to explore confidence-building measures and trade connectivity wherever feasible. With China, India should pursue practical dialogue on trans-Himalayan connectivity wherever economic interests and security concerns can be reconciled.

This transition could begin with a phased connectivity strategy. India should identify historically important trade corridors that could eventually be revived as modern economic corridors, beginning with those where security and diplomatic conditions are most conducive. This does not mean opening every route at once.

A road to opportunity

A functioning land corridor creates opportunities: at every stage, from construction, transport and warehousing to hospitality, manufacturing, agriculture, logistics, finance, technology and services. Unlike air connectivity, whose economic benefits are concentrated around a limited number of nodes, a trade corridor can generate economic activity across a wider geography through which it passes.

Most importantly, it could give the young people of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh something far more valuable than another promise. It could give them wings to fly towards new horizons.

India's demographic advantage is a window of opportunity, not a permanent condition. We cannot afford to allow a generation to grow up watching possibilities on smartphones while encountering closed doors in the real world.

For Jammu and Kashmir, the answer may lie partly in reopening doors that history once kept open. The Silk Road was never only about silk. It was about the movement of goods, people, ideas and possibilities.

It is time to view Kashmir not merely through the prism of conflict, but through the lens of enterprise, connectivity and integration. Former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee spoke of abandoning beaten paths and searching for new ways to address difficult issues. The ancient road across the Himalayas do not belong merely in history books. Reimagined as modern economic arteries, they could become pathways to opportunity, giving the next generation not another reason to wait, but a road towards a better future.

The challenge beyond factories

BYD's expansion in Europe illustrates one response. As it builds manufacturing capacity in Hungary, the company is also developing relationships with European suppliers. Xpeng has chosen another route, contracting Canadian automotive supplier Magna to assemble its vehicles in Austria. The two approaches differ, but they expose the same underlying problem: reproducing outside China is easier than reproducing outside China, the ecosystem that made production in China efficient in the first place.

What makes these ecosystems difficult to unwind or reproduce is that they consist of more than identifiable suppliers. They embody accumulated relationships between firms, specialised skills, tooling and production knowledge, logistics networks, and the ability of suppliers to respond quickly when designs or production volumes change. Many of these advantages are built through repeated interaction rather than formal contracts. This is why replacing an individual Chinese supplier does not necessarily eliminate dependence on the wider Chinese production system – and why transplanting a Chinese factory abroad does not automatically transplant the capabilities surrounding it.

Seen from this perspective, de-Sinification has a less obvious, two-sided character. Foreign firms attempting to reduce their exposure to China confront the depth of China's integration into their production networks. Chinese firms going global confront the difficulty of reproducing abroad the ecosystem on which their competitiveness depends. One side is trying to

De-Sinification is reshaping factories, but industrial ecosystems remain harder to move

A credibility crisis

The Election Commission of India (ECI)'s decision to undertake a special drive to help those left out of the SIR and make changes in its functioning is clearly a response to the investigation by The Indian Express and the brickbats that followed from the Opposition. But it would be premature to see this as a change of heart. The ECI's handling of various issues so far has raised serious

questions about its independence and sensitivity to public concerns. As a constitutional body, it was expected to function with the fierce independence seen during T.N. Seshan's tenure. Instead, a widespread perception prevails that it has become vulnerable to political pressures. As a septuagenarian voter who values honesty and sincerity, I find it deeply

troubling that such independent institutions respond more to those in power than to the Constitution, their conscience and the collective will of the citizens.

V. Nagarajan,
Chennai

The reported dissent of two Election Commissioners over the functioning of the electoral-roll revision process raises serious

questions about the working of the electoral machinery. Concerns over ERONet access, changes to Form 6 and the exclusion of eligible voters cannot be treated lightly. Yet, recording dissent alone cannot end the responsibility of constitutional functionaries. If such irregularities were considered serious, the Commissioners ought to have pursued the available institutional mechanisms to

seek their resolution. Their failure to do so also raises questions about accountability within the institution entrusted with protecting the integrity of the electoral process.

Kanhaiya Pandey,
Giridih, Jharkhand

The exposure of 14 instances of objections to unilateral decisions concerning electoral rolls points to an assault on our democracy. However, a

bureaucrat does not
weaponise a constitutional
body in a vacuum. There
appears to be a conspiracy
to engineer poll outcomes
from behind the scenes. If
constitutional institutions
are compromised, those
responsible must face legal
consequences to restore
trust.

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

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Form 26 and the statutory mandate

Although Natarajan has been granted liberty to challenge her rejection through an election petition under Section 100 of ROPA, the broader constitutional question survives. It may be time for the Supreme Court to revisit *Ponnuswami* and clarify whether constitutional courts should remain powerless even in the face of patent arbitrariness during the electoral process.

The case raises questions about the scope of the disclosure obligations imposed on candidates and constitutional remedies available when nomination papers are rejected

CM
YK

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of people rescued during floods in Chhattisgarh

5,000 Nearly 5,000 people were rescued in the last two days after heavy rains swelled rivers in Chhattisgarh, officials said on Sunday. The administration has set up 43 relief camps in urban and rural areas of the Bastar district. The Indravati river level rose to 12.56 metres by 8 p.m. on Saturday, 4.26 metres above the danger mark. PTI

People who died in separate mass shootings in S. Africa

27 The first massacre occurred late Saturday night near Johannesburg. The second happened in the early hours of Sunday near Cape Town. No arrests had been made in the two shootings, which came just five days after another mass shooting near the city of Durban killed at least 11 people. Shootings are the most common form of homicide in South Africa. PTI

Palestinians killed by Israel in Gaza since October 2023

74,016 While a ceasefire that took effect on October 10 last year has halted the heaviest fighting, Israeli strikes have continued in what the military described as responses to threats or attacks. Since the ceasefire, 1,145 Palestinians have been killed, said the Ministry, which is part of the Hamas-led government. PTI

Missing trainee teachers honoured by protesters in Mexico

43 Thousands of protesters wore red and carried symbolic coffins at a demonstration in Mexico City on Saturday, demanding answers about the 43 trainee teachers who went missing 12 years ago. Prosecutors initially said officers delivered the teacher trainees to drug cartel hitmen, who killed them. Independent human rights experts have rejected the conclusion. AFP

People rescued from child trafficking racket in Arunachal Pradesh

51 According to Namsai Superintendent of Police Sange Thinley, sustained investigation and coordinated operations led to a significant jump in rescued children from 19 during the initial phase to 51, including four adults. During the initial crackdown, the police rescued 19 children, most of them below eight years of age. PTI

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Should voting be a fundamental right?

A recent *Indian Express* report revealed an unprecedented rift within the EC over alleged unilateral changes to rules, voter additions/deletions, and centralised data access, prompting a re-examination of the argument that the ‘right to vote’ ought to be elevated from a statutory guarantee to a fundamental one

LETTER & SPIRIT

Kartikey Singh

On September 23, an *Indian Express* investigation revealed an unprecedented rift within the three-member Election Commission of India (EC), with Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi recording 14 objections over 10 months against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, regarding alleged unilateral changes to rules, voter additions/deletions, and centralised data access, without the Commission’s full approval.

The report also found that 97 eligible voters from Goa were excluded from the electoral roll after the centralised ECINet software prevented ground-level Electoral Registration Officers (ERO) from reversing decisions. More concerning, the consequences extend beyond the loss of voting rights. Reportedly, several State schemes use electoral rolls to establish eligibility, including the Goa Mediclaim Scheme. The scheme covers super-speciality treatments unavailable in government hospitals, such as dialysis, angioplasty, open-heart surgery, transplants, chemotherapy and cochlear implants, and is available only to State voters. This issue has once again cast a spotlight on the ‘right to vote’, the foundational processes of India’s electoral machinery, and the genesis of India’s ‘universal adult suffrage’ (UAS).

What shaped adult suffrage in India? India’s constitutional promise of the ‘right to vote’ differs significantly from that of many Western democracies. Reflecting the flawed belief, espoused by thinkers like J.S. Mill, that voting should be reserved for the “enlightened”, countries like the U.K. initially restricted the franchise to male property owners. Universal male suffrage emerged only in 1918, and women were granted the ‘right to vote’ a decade later in 1928. In the U.S., although the 15th and 19th Amendments extended voting rights to African Americans (1870) and women (1920), systemic barriers such as poll taxes and literacy tests continued to disenfranchise many for decades thereafter.

In sharp contrast, India’s choice of immediate, universal inclusion ensured ‘democratic equality’ from the outset, bypassing the prolonged and often violent struggles seen elsewhere. Article 326 of the Constitution granted every adult citizen the ‘right to vote’, regardless of gender, caste, religion, education, or property. This commitment to a robust, inclusive democracy found further constitutional reinforcement in a series of Supreme Court judgments, notably starting with *Kesavananda Bharati v. State of Kerala* (1973), which established democracy as part of the ‘basic structure’ doctrine. For this ideal to function meaningfully, people should be able to freely decide the fate of their government.

This inclusive vision was operationalised through two key laws: the Representation of the People Act, 1950, which governs the preparation and revision of electoral rolls; and the 1951 Act, which regulates election conduct, candidature, and electoral offences. The EC has repeatedly introduced administrative innovations to realise this ‘constitutional promise’.

Notably, the then Chief Election Commissioner Sukumar Sen, faced with the task of enrolling 173 million largely illiterate voters, turned a logistical hurdle into a democratic breakthrough by



Enabling democracy: Courts have regarded the right to vote as an inseparable part of democracy, as it enables citizens to shape governance. R. ASHOK

introducing election symbols, making UAS practically accessible.

In India, the EC has the responsibility to reach the last citizen, wherever they may be, to actualise their ‘right to elect’.

What is the legal status of right to vote?

The legal status of the ‘right to vote’ in India has long been debated, and whether it is classified as a statutory, constitutional, or fundamental right determines how easily it can be changed, how it is enforced, and the level of legal protection it receives. Although Dr. B.R. Ambedkar and K.T. Shah proposed including it in the Constitution’s fundamental rights part, the Constituent Assembly’s Advisory Committee ultimately rejected the idea. Importantly, a Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court in *Kuldip Nayar v. Union of India* (2006) held that the ‘right to elect’ is a statutory right under Section 62 of the RPA, 1951, and not a fundamental or constitutional right.

Though a two-judge Bench in *Rajbala v. State of Haryana* described the ‘right to vote’ as a constitutional right in 2015, the larger bench ruling in *Kuldip Nayar* prevails. Again, in *Anoop Baranwal v. Union of India* (2023), the top court declined to pronounce on the issue, noting that it had already been settled by the five-judge Bench in the *Kuldip Nayar* judgment. However, in his dissent, Justice Ajay Rastogi asserted that the ‘right to vote’ is an expression of Article 19(1)(a) and reflects the essence of Article 21. Yet, as this view remains a minority opinion, the ‘right to elect’ continues to be recognised as a statutory right.

Nevertheless, even though it is not a fundamental right, courts have regarded the ‘right to vote’ as an inseparable part of democracy, anchoring their reasoning in the idea that it enables citizens to shape governance, making it a “democratic imperative” vital to the Indian republic’s survival.

Why do we need accurate poll rolls?

Free and fair elections rest on accurate electoral rolls under the RPA, 1950. Inaccuracies – such as mass omissions, ineligible inclusions, duplicates, or incorrect entries – undermine the “one person, one vote” principle by enabling impersonation, disenfranchisement, or

dilution of votes, ultimately distorting the people’s mandate. Therefore, the EC is empowered under Section 21 of the 1950 Act to prepare and revise these rolls to ensure integrity. The Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023 lays down how the EC must transact its business. Section 17 requires the Commission’s business to be conducted in accordance with the Act, while Section 18 provides that its procedure and allocation of business may be regulated by unanimous decision. It further requires business to be transacted as far as possible unanimously, but where the CEC and other Commissioners differ, the matter is decided by majority.

Deriving its authority from Article 324, the EC serves as the constitutional guardian of elections, with powers of superintendence, direction, and control. A key duty is preparing accurate electoral rolls, guided by Section 19 of the RPA, 1950, which mandates that any citizen aged 18 or above, “ordinarily resident” in a constituency and not disqualified, is entitled to be registered. “Ordinary resident” implies a genuine, continuous presence, not a temporary stay.

While discrepancies may arise, courts have consistently held that only substantial and systemic errors that demonstrably “materially affected” the election outcome can compromise the sanctity of the electoral roll. Minor mistakes or isolated disenfranchisement are insufficient.

Yet the recent Goa episode complicates this comfortable “substantial versus isolated” binary that courts have relied on. The *Indian Express* report revealed that 97 eligible voters were dropped from the rolls, not through electoral fraud but because the ECINet software architecture itself denied EROs the authority to reverse erroneous deletions. What makes the episode damning is not merely the exclusion, but the apparent unresponsiveness that followed. The EROs reportedly flagged the anomalies to the Commission by email, yet the corrections were not restored. This is not the isolated clerical error that courts have historically forgiven; it is a systemic failure baked into the software’s design, compounded by administrative inertia.

While the right to inclusion or

objection in electoral rolls is conferred on individuals, not political parties, the court in *Lakshmi Charan Sen v. A.K.M. Hassan Uzzaman* (1985) observed that in a largely illiterate and politically unaware electorate, parties should take steps to ensure eligible voters are included, and ineligible ones are removed. Given India’s party-based Parliamentary system, such vigilance will help in preserving ‘electoral integrity’.

What lies ahead?

The revelations against the EC lend fresh urgency to the argument that the ‘right to vote’ ought to be elevated from a statutory guarantee to a fundamental one. If the body constitutionally tasked with safeguarding the franchise can itself be riven by disputes over unilateral action, leaving the citizen’s only recourse to the EC’s internal correction mechanisms, or to a statutory right that the Parliament could dilute at will, is precarious.

Many scholars argue that the ‘right to vote’ cannot be regarded as merely a statutory right, as it flows from Article 326, and any legislation regulating it must conform to the parameters prescribed by Articles 325 and 326. It is therefore necessary to ensure that the legislature does not impose irrational or unreasonable restrictions on the ‘right to vote’, particularly since “free and fair elections” and “democracy” are basic features of the Constitution.

Justice Rastogi’s dissent in *Anoop Baranwal*, over the legal status of the ‘right to vote’, offers doctrinal ground for a larger Bench to revisit the question that the majority in *Kuldip Nayar* considered settled.

Elevating the ‘right to vote’ to fundamental status would not diminish the EC’s authority to purify rolls; it would instead subject that authority to the heightened standard of judicial review reserved for fundamental rights, ensuring that the drive to centralise electoral administration is always weighed against, rather than allowed to override, the citizen’s claim to be counted. In a democracy where software now mediates the relationship between the voter and the ballot, the constitutional status of the ‘right to vote’ can no longer remain a matter of legislative grace. (*Kartikey Singh is a lawyer based in New Delhi.*)

THE GIST

India’s choice of immediate, universal adult suffrage ensured democratic equality from the outset. Article 326 of the Constitution granted every adult citizen the ‘right to vote’

An *Indian Express* report revealed that 97 eligible voters from Goa were dropped from the rolls because the ECINet software denied EROs the authority to reverse erroneous deletions. This is not an isolated clerical error, but a systemic failure, compounded by administrative inertia

If the body constitutionally tasked with safeguarding the voting rights can be riven by disputes over unilateral action, leaving the citizen’s only recourse to the EC’s internal correction mechanisms, or to a statutory right that the Parliament could dilute at will is precarious

CACHE



Expanding dragnet: ICE has received billions of dollars in funding during U.S. President Donald Trump's second term, and dramatically ramped up its presence. REUTERS

How Big Tech companies contribute to anti-immigration crackdowns

As the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) increases its presence, Big Tech firms are facing both internal and external pressure to take a stronger stance against the controversial agency

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far: On September 15, a small group of protesters assembled near San Francisco's Moscone Center, the venue for Salesforce's annual tech event, calling for an end to any and all contracts between the company and the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), as thousands of attendees passed by them to watch CEO Marc Benioff's keynote. Though Big Tech firms have long sought out U.S. government contracts, specific links to ICE are now sparking employee discomfort, customer protests, and calls for boycotts.

What is ICE and why is it controversial? ICE was established as a federal law enforcement agency, with a mission to protect the U.S. from cross-border crime and illegal immigration, after the country witnessed the heinous terrorist attacks on September 11, 2001. The agency has received billions of dollars in funding during U.S. President Donald Trump's second term, and dramatically ramped up its presence. Arrests have spiked, along with the use of violence against citizens. Untoward law enforcement incidents in Minneapolis are a case in point. In January, writer and mother Renée Good, 37, was killed by a federal immigration officer in the city. Days later, nurse Alex Pretti, 37, was killed by Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officials while intervening in an ICE operation. Even though there have been reports of multiple detained foreigners dying in ICE custody, the killings of two American

citizens triggered bipartisan outrage and protests. ICE says that it "does not detain unaccompanied children – except in rare instances." But a report by the *New York Times* in February revealed that the agency was detaining hundreds of children. Another report by *Marshall Project*, a not-for-profit news organisation, said that over 6,200 children were detained by ICE during Mr. Trump's second term.

Does U.S. Big Tech work with ICE? Large tech companies often seek high-profile government contracts with federal agencies as they provide regular revenue streams and boost their reputation. The partnerships range from allowing advertisements for the agency's recruitment efforts to directly fulfilling ICE's online and offline needs. But tech firms are divided in how they support ICE. While defence-focused data analytics firm Palantir is proud of its business relationship with ICE, customer relationship management tech firm Salesforce has adopted a more cautious and centrist approach. Palantir's contract with the U.S. government began under the Obama administration in 2011, and has continued through four administrations. "Palantir is enabling ICE to utilise our platform to better track the immigration lifecycle and serve our national security while promoting efficiency, transparency, and accountability. By improving data integration and data-dependent workflows, our software can help ICE more effectively and reliably perform its core functions," Palantir said in a blog post. Salesforce, on the other hand, per CEO

Marc Benioff's Dreamforce keynote, said that all 50 U.S. States and 15 cabinet agencies use the company's service. Salesforce's arrangement with federal agencies has been a cause of concern for its employees since 2018, according to several media reports. More recently, in February, over 1,400 Salesforce employees wrote a letter calling on Mr. Benioff to stop promoting Salesforce AI contracts to ICE, and to push back against the rising presence of ICE agents in the U.S. "We are deeply troubled by recent press reports describing Salesforce pitches of AI technology to U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) to help the agency 'expeditiously' hire 10,000 new agents and vet tip-line reports," stated the employees' letter, as reported by *CNBC*. Mr. Benioff had also previously cracked a joke about ICE agents tracking foreign employees during a company event, as per a *404 Media* report. Robin Washington, Salesforce's President and Chief Operating and Financial Officer, stressed that the company valued equality and trust, in response to *The Hindu's* questions on anti-ICE protesters. "I think anytime you attract 50,000 people, to Salesforce, you're going to have people that come with different perspectives and viewpoints. Our goal here is to put on a very future-forward opportunity for people to understand our vision, which is 'AI meets the number one AI CRM' [Customer Relationship Management] and we hope that everyone will participate and learn from that, whether they're a protestor or a stakeholder, you know – we try to create an environment where it's safe for everyone to come and bring their voice,"

Ms. Washington told *The Hindu*. She explained that Salesforce had multiple vehicles through which leadership could engage directly with employees who had different perspectives. **Are tech boycotts effective?** Immigrant advocacy platforms have called for boycotts against tech companies including Amazon and Microsoft for allegedly providing cloud services to ICE. Boycott calls have targeted Apple for removing anti-ICE apps, as well as Google, LinkedIn, Meta, Spotify, and YouTube for allegedly running ICE-related recruitment ads on their platforms. Other tech companies on boycott lists include AT&T, Comcast, Dell, Clearview AI, IBM, and X. Non-technology companies have also faced flak for feeding and housing ICE agents, apart from helping them operate charter flights and private prisons. However, the sheer number of companies with both direct and indirect ICE links complicates boycott efforts. Even so, the public reporting surrounding ICE spending means that everyday citizens can access the facts that they need to hold their local companies accountable. "Salesforce has a history of showing up for our communities. As a Bay Area tech leader, Salesforce has an opportunity to use its influence to defend democracy, refuse to profit from family separation, [and] to push the tech industry to follow," stated part of a flyer that protesters handed out to *The Hindu* on the first day of the Dreamforce event. This month, the *NBC* news outlet cited a senior U.S. official to report that ICE agents arrested around 50,000 people in August.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Test your knowledge of the life and career of legendary singer Lata Mangeshkar on her 97th birth anniversary

V.V. Ramanan

- QUESTION 1**
What was her birth name before her parents renamed her after a character (Latika) from one of her father's plays?
- QUESTION 2**
What is the significance of the song *Paa Lagoon Kar Jori* for the 1946 film *Aap Ki Sewa Mein*?
- QUESTION 3**
Name the music director who backed her, after she was rejected for a having a 'thin voice', famously remarking that filmmakers would "fall at her feet" to get her to sing?
- QUESTION 4**
What is common to the songs: *Beeti*

- Na Bitai Raina (Parichay)*, *Roothi Roothi Piya (Kora Kaagaz)* and *Yaara Seeli Seeli (Lekin)*?
- QUESTION 5**
Under what name did she compose music for Marathi films in the 1960s?
- QUESTION 6**
Name the Lata rendition penned by Kavi Pradeep and composed by C. Ramachandra that brought PM Jawaharlal Nehru to tears in 1963.
- QUESTION 7**
She sang the thumri *Kanha Main Tose Hari* for the only Hindi film of which celebrated director who also composed the music?
- QUESTION 8**
In which year was she awarded the Bharat Ratna?



Visual question: In which city is this installation located at a place named 'Lata Chowk'? SANDEEP SAXENA

- Questions and answers to the previous daily quiz:** 1. This Ministry is responsible for the administration of the National Film Awards. **Ans: Information and Broadcasting**
2. The only actress to be honoured for her performances in two different films at the same time. **Ans: Kangana Ranaut**
3. Mammootty has won four National Awards so far. He shares this achievement with another actor. **Ans: Amitabh Bachchan**
4. This person has won the maximum number of National Awards under the 'best feature film' category. **Ans: Satyajit Ray**
5. In 2024, some prestigious categories were renamed. The award for best debut film was under the name of a former Prime Minister and the award for best feature film on national integration under the name of a famous actor. **Ans: Indira Gandhi; Nargis Dutt**
- Visual:** The subject of the first Indian motion picture and the man who made the motion picture. **Ans: Raja Harishchandra; Dadasaheb Phalke**
- Early birds:** K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Mohan Lal Patel | C. Saravanan | Sunil Madhavan



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

I was scolded for forgetting my homework

The school's infrastructure was in dire straits due to lack of funds

S. Upendran

What is the meaning and origin of the expression 'dire straits'? (R. Sivakumar, Erode) First, let us deal with the pronunciation of the two words. 'Dire' rhymes with 'higher', 'fire' and 'tyre', while 'strait' is pronounced like the word 'straight'. The phrase is pronounced 'dier - STRAIGHTS' with the stress on the second word. When you say that you are 'in dire straits', it means that you are in deep trouble; you are in such a bad situation you are unlikely to find a solution to your problem. It is a situation which causes you a lot of worry or concern. When the monsoon failed for the second consecutive year, farmers were in dire straits. The team was in dire straits when their best batsman broke his foot while fielding. America's war with Iran has made people across the world familiar with the Strait of Hormuz – which Donald Trump would like to rename 'Trump Strait'. The word 'strait' is normally used to refer to a narrow body of water flowing between land masses. This narrow stretch of water connects two large bodies of water – the Strait of Hormuz, for example, connects the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman. The expression 'dire straits' comes from the world of shipping, and it was mostly used to highlight the difficulty or challenge posed while navigating the narrow waters of a strait. With the passage of time, the expression took on a broader meaning. Today, it is mostly used to talk about any kind of difficulty. The word 'dire' originally meant 'fearful' and 'boding ill', but today the term is mostly used to mean 'serious or extreme'. The people affected by the recent floods are in dire need of help.

What is the difference between 'shout at' and 'scold'? (R. Rukmani, Chennai) One normally 'scolds' people that one has a close relationship or familiar with. When you scold someone, you normally do it because you wish to change or correct their existing behaviour. When you do this, you may choose to speak in your normal voice or increase your volume. The teacher scolded the children for not doing their homework. 'Scolde', from which we get 'scold', was used as a noun in informal contexts to refer to an abusive and quarrelsome person. With the passage of time, the legal term 'common scold' began to be applied to women who were a public nuisance – women who argued loudly with their neighbours and abused people in public. It was only in the 14th century that 'scold' began to be used as a verb to mean 'to find fault with'. When you 'shout at' someone, you always do so by speaking loudly; there is no attempt here to correct the behaviour of the person. You are very upset about what the person has done, and are merely giving vent to your anger. Hemant shouted at the taxi driver for his rash driving. upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

- Unctuous:** unpleasantly and excessively suave in manner or speech
- Synonyms:** fulsome, oleaginous, smarmy
- Usage:** *The politician's unctuous apology failed to convince the voters.*
- Pronunciation:** newsth.live/unctuous
- International Phonetic Alphabet:** /ˈʌŋ(k)ˈtʃuəs/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

CJP leader, 41 volunteers detained by Assam Police

They were released in the evening; CJP spokesperson says the detainees were not served with any legal notice; CJP wanted to talk about fixing the pathetic condition of schools in Assam, he says

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Assam Police on Sunday detained Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka and several others from a private residence in Guwahati. They were released later in the evening.

According to CJP spokesperson Anish Gawande, the others included 41 local volunteers and Mr. Ranka's associates, Ankit Bharadwaj and Prem Aakash.

"Six of those detained along with Ashutosh Ranka are women. They were taken to the [Dispur] police station from a private residence, where a meet-up of CJP volunteers was scheduled," Mr. Gawande told presspersons.

"The illegal detention by Assam Police has finally ended. We have asked Police to go and drop us from where we were picked up illegally in the first place," Mr. Ranka said in a post on



Rallying cry: CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka at a protest ahead of its first regional volunteers' meeting in Assam on Sunday. PTI

X after being released along with the other detainees.

The CJP leaders and volunteers were not served with any legal notice, and they were also not told which sections of the law they had been detained under, Mr. Gawande said.

"This is nothing short of jungle raj under Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, who is afraid of any and all kind of dissent," Mr. Gawande said.

All the CJP wanted to talk about was fixing the pathetic condition of schools in Assam, which do not have fans, classrooms, and teachers, he said.

"We wanted to talk about the way people have been evicted from Kaziranga, their lands taken, and activists arrested. We wanted to talk about the illegal redrawing of the election (constituency) boundaries in Assam," he said.

The CJP alleged that there had been a pattern in Assam "happening for too long".

"You have seen what happened with land rights activist Pranab Doley, who was arrested and then detained under the National Security Act. You have seen how the government intimidates civil society activists in Assam," Mr. Gawande said.

'Chief Minister is afraid' Earlier in the day, Mr. Ranka asked why the Chief Minister was afraid of being exposed.

"The Chief Minister is scared that if we show the schools here, the country will know the reality. He is afraid that people will know how their rights were being snatched in Kaziranga for the benefit of the corporates. But we are not afraid of him. We know that he won the Assembly election by redrawing boundaries of constituencies," Mr. Ranka said.

CPI(M) leader, AAP chief discuss EC row, ED action against ex-Keralam CM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of the INDIA bloc meeting scheduled for September 30 to discuss the functioning of the Election Commission, CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby met Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convenor and former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal in Delhi on Sunday.

The leaders discussed the recent report on Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar allegedly ignoring objections raised by the two Election Commissioners on the special intensive revision exercise and the Enforcement Directorate's action against former Keralam Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan.

The meeting comes days after Mr. Baby wrote to INDIA bloc parties and other non-NDA parties seeking a joint discussion on developments following reports of differences within the poll panel over the SIR exercise. Setting aside three-decade-old differences,



CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby at Aam Aadmi Party national convenor Arvind Kejriwal's residence in New Delhi on Sunday. PTI

Mr. Baby spoke to the chairperson of the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress, Mamata Banerjee, who agreed that the situation warranted coordinated action.

Meeting agenda

Mr. Baby said his primary purpose was to invite Mr. Kejriwal to participate in the Left campaign against the alleged misuse of Central investigation agencies. He underlined that the Enforcement Directorate, which had been used against Mr. Kejriwal and his colleague Manish Sisodia, was now being deployed

against former Keralam Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan in what he described as a sustained attempt to tarnish his image. The two leaders also discussed the "authoritarian manner" in which Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar was functioning and the need for a united Opposition effort to expose his alleged wrongdoing.

The INDIA bloc meeting is expected to discuss the functioning of the Election Commission, the SIR exercise, and the Opposition's course of action, including seeking the removal of CEC Gyanesh Kumar.

Mamata camp leader faces attack twice in two days

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

Beleghata MLA Kunal Ghosh was allegedly attacked on Sunday and his vehicle was damaged by unidentified miscreants.

This was the second attack on the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) leader in two days. Mr. Ghosh was attacked at Uttarpara in Hooghly district on Saturday when he was on the way to attend a meeting called by former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

"Today I was once again the target of an attempted murder. It all happened in the city of Kolkata, in broad daylight and on a Sunday, when I was on my way to attend a programme as an MLA. They were armed; they smashed the car window and tried to drag me out, brandishing revolvers. My security personnel had to draw their weapons," Mr. Ghosh said.

The journalist-turned-politician lodged a complaint at the Narkeldanga police station.

CEC row: CM criticises Mamata for joining hands with CPI(M)

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Amid the controversy surrounding the Election Commission (EC), West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Sunday criticised former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee for joining hands with the Communist Party of India (Marxist) and accused her of deliberately creating confusion over the role of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

"The Opposition is deliberately creating confusion and controversy over a recent newspaper report," the Chief Minister said.

CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby had approached Ms. Banerjee over the ongoing controversy, and Ms. Banerjee had agreed that her party and the CPI(M) were on the same page in this matter. She said that she had a discussion with Congress leaders and that the Opposition would hold a

meeting on the issue. Leaders of the Opposition INDIA bloc are likely to meet on September 30.

"Trinamool was formed to end the atrocities and injustice of 34 years of CPI(M) rule. The same CPI(M) has now become its friend," Mr. Adhikari said.

His remarks came a day after Ms. Banerjee sharpened her attack on Mr. Kumar, alleging that the SIR was being used to help the BJP capture Bengal and demanded fresh elections with the pre-SIR voter list.

Over 2,000 citizens write to CJI to stay SIR, start suo motu proceedings on EC conduct

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Over 2,000 citizens across the country have signed an open letter to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant to initiate *suo motu* proceedings against the operational and administrative conduct of the Election Commission of India regarding the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise and the deployment of ECINet.

The letter seeks the immediate stay and rescission of the SIR exercise across all States and Union Territories pending a thorough, independent judicial review of its legality and procedural integrity in light of the new facts that have emerged.

They have also sought an independent, court-monitored investigation into allegations of arbitrary, unauthorised changes made to voter registration software/forms. The open letter has sought a direct

tion from the court for "appropriate penal/procedural action against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and officials for overriding statutory procedures and disregarding the constitutional mandate of the multi-member Commission".

The signatories have also sought a comprehensive security and legal audit of the ECINet software platform by an independent expert committee appointed by the top court to res-

store decentralised control to local Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) as mandated by law and verify whether any persons other than statutory officers had access to the platform.

The letter urged the court's intervention to order the immediate reinstatement of voters whose names were deleted.

"When the institutional safeguards designed to protect the electoral roll are compromised from

within, judicial intervention becomes vital to preserve public faith in the democratic process," the letter said.

The signatories include academic Aditya Nigam, filmmaker Aditya Seth, Admiral Vishnu Bhagwat (retired), retired IAS officer Aditi Mehta, activists Amrita Johri and Anjali Bhardwaj, former DU professor Anita Rampal, retired JNU Professor Nivedita Menon, advocate Prashant Bhushan and actor Prakash Raj.

BJP slams Rahul over SIR, accuses Opposition parties of maligning institutions

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday fielded its Chief Ministers and stepped up its attack on the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, the Congress, and its allies over the special intensive revision (SIR), accusing them of making unsubstantiated claims.

Alleging that Mr. Gandhi and other Opposition leaders were conspiring to malign the country's constitutional institutions, the BJP said the Election Commission of India had already issued a press note and a fact-based clarification of the "fabricated allegations".

"Despite this, the Congress and its allies, frustrated by their repeated electoral defeats, remain determined to undermine constitutional propriety in an attempt to conceal their failures. From North to South and East to West, this misinformation aimed at weakening the country's democratic framework and creating anarchy is being strongly countered across the nation," the party said in a statement.

Chief Ministers Yogi Adityanath, Devendra Fadnavis, Himanta Biswa Sarma, Bhajan Lal Sharma, Bhupendra Patel, Nayab Singh Saini, Vishnu Deo Sai, Pushkar Singh Dhami, Rekha Gupta, Samrat Choudhary, Mohan Yadav and Suwendu Adhikari hit out at the Congress.

Mr. Fadnavis accused Mr. Gandhi of seeking to discredit institutions under the guise of defending the Constitution and deliberately creating confusion and chaos by repeatedly questioning constitution-



Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis dismisses vote-theft claims, saying Rahul Gandhi's 'mind has been stolen'. FILE

al bodies. "There has been no vote theft, Rahul Gandhi's mind has been stolen," he said.

Alleging that the Opposition parties had created confusion over the SIR, Mr. Adityanath sought an apology from the Congress and its allies.

Mr. Sarma described the Opposition as an "alliance of defeated people", while Mr. Yadav alleged that Mr. Gandhi was spreading falsehoods after failing to manage his party.

Ms. Gupta demanded an apology, accusing the Opposition of "creating this baseless controversy to divert attention from its failures, its betrayal of the country and the development works being undertaken".

Mr. Adhikari said the Congress supported SIR in Kerala because it won there but opposed it in West Bengal after losing the election.

He said judicial officers were dealing with names rejected due to logical discrepancies, adding that the Opposition was misleading the public.

TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF TELANGANA LIMITED
E - PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE
The TGTRANSCO invites bids online for the following work: 1) Spec.No. e-TGTLI-17/2026-27, Name of work: Supply, Erection, Testing and commissioning of Conversion of existing 132kV 2-Ph DC line to 3-Ph DC line (4.5km) from 220/132kV SS Malyalapalli & erection of new 132kV 3-Ph DC line of 4km to proposed 132kV Ramagundam RTSS along with connected bays at 220/132kV SS Malyalapalli and 132kV Ramagundam RTSS. 2) Spec.No.e-TGTLI-18/2026-27, Name of work: Supply of Material/Equipment including Transportation & Insurance, Delivery, Erection, Testing & Commissioning and Civil & Construction of the following works on Turnkey basis in Narayanpet District: (i)220/11kV LISS at Vutkur, Bapur(V), Vutkur(M) (ii) 220kV TMDC Line from proposed 220/11kV SS at Budpur SS to proposed 220/11kV SS at Vutkur SS (24.574KM), (iii) 220kV TMDC Line from proposed 220/11kV Jayammacheruvu SS to proposed 220/11kV LISS at Vutkur (13.073KM) under Makthal- Narayanpet- Kodangal Lift Irrigation Scheme-(Package-2) Tender Availability on website from: 28.09.2026. Note: Further details can be seen in website: <http://tender.telangana.gov.in> FAX NO. 040-23323565, Phone No.040-23396000 Extn.3552/3424/3644/3415/3687/3627. DIPR R.O. No. 582-PPCL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Sd/- CHIEF ENGINEER/LIS

TOURISM CORPORATION OF GUJARAT LIMITED (TCGL)
(A Government of Gujarat undertaking)
Nigam Bhavan Sector 16, Block C First Floor, Nr. GH 4½ Bus Stand, Gandhinagar – 382 016. Website: <https://www.gujarattourism.com>
TENDER NOTICE
Bids are invited from reputed and experienced Agencies for providing service towards "Third-Party Inspection Agencies for Monitoring and Inspection of Cleaning and Sanitation Services across various tourist locations in Gujarat". The project requirements, technical specifications, eligibility criteria, selection process, etc. are included in the Tender documents, which shall be available for download from the websites: <https://tender.nprocure.com/> and <https://www.gujarattourism.com> from 28/09/2026 onwards. The last date for submission of the Technical Bid and Financial Bid (online only) is 19/10/2026 up to 6:00 pm. and Technical Bid (physical only) is 22/10/2026 up to 3:00 pm. Managing Director

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, MEGA LIFT, BHUBANESWAR.
Plot No.A 8/2, Bhoinagar, Bhubaneswar, Odisha, PIN-751022, E-Mail : cemlpwr.od@gmail.com
Government of Odisha - "e" Procurement Notice
(Bid Identification No. 15ML/2026-27)
The Chief Engineer, Megalift on behalf of the Governor of Odisha invites online tender through "E"procurement for the works as detailed in the Annexure to this bid notice.
ANNEXURE TO BID NOTICE

Name of the work	Appointment of Third Party Inspection Agency (TPIA) for Implementation of Mega Lift projects in Cluster No. XXXI & XXXVI.
Cost of Tender Paper	Rs.10,000/-
EMD/Bid Security	Rs.1,29,000/-
Mode of payment of tender paper Cost & EMD	Online
Period of Completion	36(Thirty-Six) Calendar months
Availability of Bid document for sale and receipt through on-line	From dt.29.09.2026, 10.00 A.M. to dt.21.10.2026, up to 5.00 P.M
Last date / time of receipt of bid in the portal	21.10.2026 (5.00 PM)
Date of Pre-bid Conference	12.10.2026, 11.00 AM
Date of opening of Techno-Commercial bid through online	On dt. 22.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M in the Office of the Chief Engineer, Megalift.
Class of Contractor	The bidder should be registered under the Companies Act,1956/2013
Digital Signature Certificate of Bidder	The Bidder must possess compatible digital signature certificate (DSC).
The detail tender call notice can also be seen in the DOWR web site - https://dowr.odisha.gov.in	
Name & Address of the OIT	Chief Engineer, Megalift, Plot No. A-8/2, Bhoi Nagar, Bhubaneswar- 751022, Ph.No-0674-2567252, Email ID : cemlpwr.od@gmail.com
Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement market place, https://tendersodisha.gov.in	

Chief Engineer, Megalift, Bhubaneswar.
32001/919/2627 OIPR-32001/324781/26-27/0014

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M ND-NDE

INBRIEF



3-storey building collapses in Haryana; 4 dead, 12 injured

Four people died while more than ten were injured when a three-storeyed building under construction collapsed at Dhulkot village near Ambala City in Haryana on Sunday, officials said. The incident unfolded in the late afternoon when the concrete slab (lintel) for the roof was being cast on the first floor, prompting locals to initiate rescue efforts before informing the police and emergency services. One of the injured workers claimed that some labourers were working on the ground floor, while others were engaged in the casting work above. Ambala Civil Surgeon Renu Beri told reporters that 12 injured labourers were brought to the hospital, of whom five are still admitted, two were discharged on request, while the others were discharged after first aid. PTI

IndiGo A321 plane involved in another tail strike

An IndiGo Airbus A321 was involved in yet another tail strike at Bengaluru airport on Sunday, marking at least the ninth known such incident involving the airline's A321 fleet. In a statement, IndiGo said an "abnormal runway contact" occurred during "gusty wind conditions" in Bengaluru. The aircraft was operating a flight from Guwahati. It aborted its initial landing attempt at Bengaluru airport before making a final landing at 12.15 p.m., industry sources said. A tail strike occurs when the rear section of an aircraft comes into contact with the runway during landing, take-off, or a go-around.

Census 2027 is a 'national responsibility', says Modi

Data of over 32 crore families has already been recorded during the nationwide exercise, PM says in *Mann Ki Baat*; he also highlights Indian armed forces' decisive response to terror attacks

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

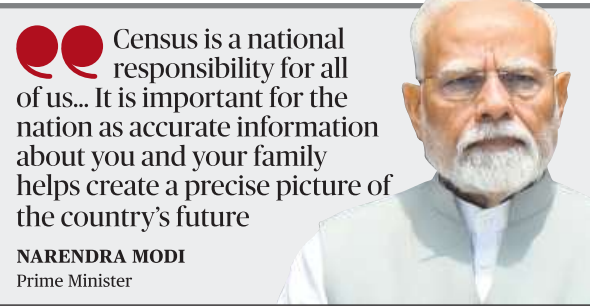
Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday described Census 2027 as a national responsibility requiring public participation. With over 32 crore families recorded and 2.6 crore people having self-enumerated digitally, he said accurate information about people and their families would help create a precise picture of the country's future.

During his *Mann Ki Baat* address, Mr. Modi said: "The facility to self-register your Census details is very convenient. You can register information about yourself and your family from your mobile itself."

"The first phase of this exercise is nearly complete across all States and Union Territories; data of over 32 crore families has already been recorded," he said.

Over 2.6 crore people had already entered their details on the Census portal through mobile phones without uploading any documents, he added.

During his address, Mr. Modi paid tributes to the victims of the September



2008 Delhi serial blasts, the 26/11 Mumbai attack and the 9/11 U.S. terrorist attacks.

Recalling India's surgical strike on September 28-29, 2016, he said the Indian Army demonstrated a decisive response by crossing the Line of Control to target terrorist hideouts in Pakistan. He highlighted the Balakot air strike and Operation Sindoor as instances of India's zero-tolerance counter-terrorism approach.

On the "Somnath Swabhimani Parv", he said Mahmud of Ghazni demolished the Somnath Temple for the first time in 1026 and the same year, the Sun Temple in Gujarat's Modherna was also attacked and destroyed. He said despite invasions and destruction of temples, the people and rulers of that period did

not lose their resolve and rebuilt them.

Praise for expert

Mr. Modi hailed the contribution of A. Selvaraju, associated with the Department of Tamil Studies at a college in Manapparai in Tamil Nadu's Tiruchirappalli.

He said Mr. Selvaraju discovered several sculptures and ancient temples, helping people understand and connect with the past.

Referring to the recently concluded Ganesh Chaturthi celebrations, Mr. Modi noted that India's spiritual and cultural heritage transcended national boundaries, citing Thailand resident

Panthoun Thirkhanon's decades-long study and promotion of Ganesha traditions in that country.

With Mahatma Gandhi's

birth anniversary approaching on October 2, he said cleanliness was one of Gandhiji's guiding principles.

Green drive

On environment conservation, he noted the achievements made in the Sonai Rupai Wildlife Sanctuary, Assam, where land was cleared of encroachment for the once-displaced elephants to return to their natural habitat.

In West Bengal's Sundarbans, some women from Jharkhali – most of whom lost their husbands to tiger attacks – were creating mangrove forests, which were not only serving as a natural protective shield for villages but also creating income opportunities, Mr. Modi said.

Stating that the month of September is dedicated to the fight against malnutrition, he noted that Chhattisgarh was promoting *moringa* through "*Har Ghar Munga*"; Gujarat was encouraging nutritious millet dishes through "*Vangi Spardha*"; Maharashtra was conducting nutrition-awareness campaigns; and Mizoram was supporting "*Poshan Vatikas*".

PM pays tribute to Ashok Singhal on his birth centenary

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday paid tribute to former Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) international working president Ashok Singhal on his birth centenary, describing him as an "organisational genius" and recalling his "pivotal role" in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement.

In an op-ed article, Mr. Modi recalled his many interactions with Singhal, who was born on September 27, 1926, and passed away on November 17, 2015. "I consider it a privilege that I had innumerable opportunities to interact with Ashok Ji and receive his affection," Mr. Modi wrote. "One of the earliest instances dates back to 1981, when I was a young *Karyakarta* going about the organisational duties given to me. I received a handwritten letter from him," he added. "Naturally, it was a noteworthy moment for me."

Mr. Modi highlighted Singhal's role in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement. "Who can forget his address at the Boat Club Rally in 1991," he asked. "Or the defining image of an injured and bleeding Ashok Ji at the peak of the movement. Today, if there is a grand Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, it is because of stalwarts like him who selflessly immersed themselves in the effort to make it possible." "He would have been the happiest person on seeing the Ram Mandir take shape in Ayodhya," Mr. Modi wrote.

"His mind was constant-

He hailed the former VHP international working president's 'pivotal role' in Ram Janmabhoomi movement

ly running, thinking about what more one can do for those on the margins of society," Mr. Modi recalled. "Whenever any part of the nation was affected by a natural disaster, Ashok Ji was either among the first to reach there himself or among those guiding *Karyakartas* to help those affected. My own experience with him in the aftermath of the 2001 Kutch earthquake was unforgettable."

Mr. Modi highlighted Singhal's role in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement. "Who can forget his address at the Boat Club Rally in 1991," he asked. "Or the defining image of an injured and bleeding Ashok Ji at the peak of the movement. Today, if there is a grand Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, it is because of stalwarts like him who selflessly immersed themselves in the effort to make it possible." "He would have been the happiest person on seeing the Ram Mandir take shape in Ayodhya," Mr. Modi wrote.

Tribal students to embark on 180-km march to Mumbai

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
NASHIK

Hundreds of tribal students in Maharashtra will embark on a nearly 180-km march from Nashik to Mumbai on Monday, pressing the government to address their demands for better facilities, safety, and accountability in government-run residential schools.

Spearheaded by the Sakal Adivasi Vidyarthi Andolan Kruti Samiti, the long march comes 40 days after a sit-in at the Idgah Maidan in Nashik. The protest continues, with a small slate declaring the day of protest hanging from the ceiling of a temporary pandal. Posters of Birsu Munda, Bhagat Singh and Dr. B.R. Ambedkar surround the protesters as they take turns to sit on strike.

Among the demands of the protesters are the resig-



Tribal students at the sit-in at Nashik's Idgah Maidan. The protest has been going on for the past 40 days. VINAYA DESHPANDE PANDIT

nation of Maharashtra Tribal Development Minister Ashok Uike, the transfer of the Tribal Development Department's Secretary and Commissioner, basic facilities in tribal schools and hostels, an independent inquiry into tribal students' deaths at residential schools, and financial assistance for victims.

"Last month, the government held discussions with protesters from Pune and Nagpur. Tribals from

Nashik did not join them. The government gave them false promises. We are in touch with tribals from Nashik, Khandesh, North Maharashtra, Marathwada, and Vidarbha. We expect around 1,500 students to join us on the first day of the protest march," tribal leader Rahul Pawra told *The Hindu*. Protesters also raised concerns over the food provided by central kitchens to tribal schools.

Student's death can't be seen in isolation: IIT-Bombay alumni

Vinaya Vilas Deshpande
MUMBAI

The death by suicide of Sahil Wakode cannot be viewed in isolation, alumni of Indian Institute of Technology-Bombay (IITB) said on Sunday. The incident pointed to a deeper problem within the academic environment, they said. In a letter written to the Director of the institute, a group of alumni have also expressed concerns over the increasingly "militarised campus" during exams. Calling for immediate, comprehensive reforms, they sought a survey of the students' mental health and a humane approach to deal with instances of misconduct.

The alumni expressed deep anguish about a series of deaths by suicide at the institute. The 10 de-

mands put forth by them include a call for an immediate and impartial investigation into specific allegations of caste-based harassment and improved mental health support, including mandatory faculty sensitisation.

"We sincerely hope that the institute will take concrete steps to ensure that the academic climate at IITB is egalitarian, humane and conducive to intellectual growth. This requires addressing the caste, class and gender-based inequalities... that are deeply embedded in our society and can manifest within academic institutions," the letter, accessed by *The Hindu*, stated.

[Those in distress may contact Sanjivini, Society for Mental Health suicide prevention helpline: 011-40769002.]

Boeing finds glitch in guidance system of some 737-MAX planes

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

Boeing has detected a software issue in some of its B737-MAX planes that could result in disengagement of the automated flight guidance system after a missed landing approach, and the aircraft maker is working on a permanent solution, according to sources.

In India, there are 96 Boeing 737-MAX planes operated by Air India Express (53) and Akasa Air (43).

"Last month, we informed all 737 operators about a software issue where pilots may experience a reduction in automation during a landing scenario. We shared information with operators that reinforced existing pilot procedures for safely handling such cases," the spokesperson said in a statement.



Boeing has issued an advisory to operators to reset the system as a precautionary measure to address the issue. FILE PHOTO

Boeing has issued an advisory to operators to reset the system following a missed approach as a precautionary measure to address the issue, sources said.

"We are closely coordinating with Boeing and can confirm that there is no impact to the safety of Akasa Air operations. Our aircraft continue to operate safely in accordance with established procedures and applicable regulatory requirements," an airline

spokesperson said in a statement.

However, the carrier did not specifically mention whether any of its Boeing 737-MAX planes had been impacted due to the issue. There was no response from Air India Express.

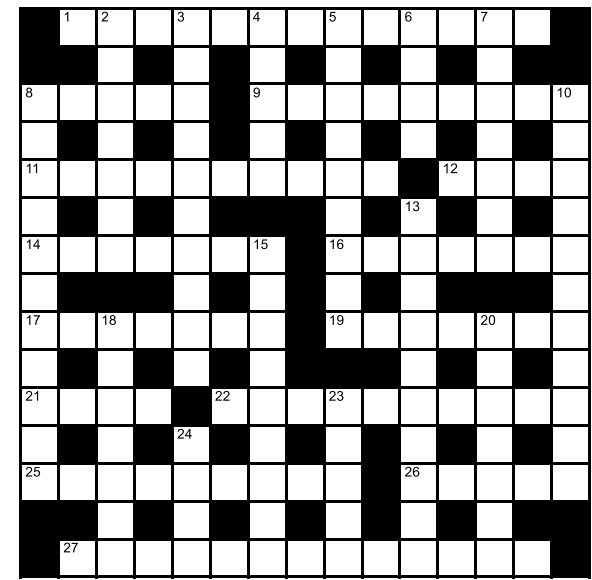
There was no immediate response from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation on whether it was probing the issue and whether any advisory was issued to airlines.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14909

(set by Dr. X)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY

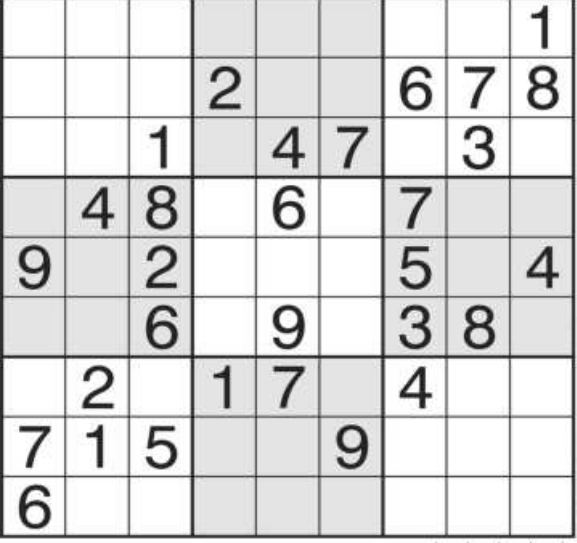


- 16 Asserting briefly about making a bloomer (7)
- 17 Deceiver cheers up after ensnaring maiden (7)
- 19 Small tin can made of tin (7)
- 21 Lover starts to cuddle at first (4)
- 22 Liaison at rave after consuming cocaine - becoming rebellious (10)
- 25 Cause a commotion in bar, catching date embracing hot lady (5,4)
- 26 Lyric poet turned very tense, entertaining princess (5)
- 27 Art of artfully reshaping with latest in 3D CGI (7,6)

- Down
- 2 Runner's not at all well, close to collapse (7)
 - 3 Love smart American couple welcoming members at launch individually (3,2,1,4)
 - 4 Content of natural ginseng gum (5)
 - 5 Desires remuneration after end of therapy (9)
 - 6 Bishop, one wearing outsize sashes (4)
 - 7 Model consuming ecstasy with posh fellow turned miserable (7)
 - 8 Specialist beginning to chat about treatment of neurosis (11)
 - 10 Knight in position trapping one's rook with clean moves (3,8)
 - 13 Goad union's ridiculous dinosaurs (10)
 - 15 Peaceful, having good time on island's national park (9)
 - 18 Woman drinking wine, becoming more reckless (7)
 - 20 Nudging to control one talking loudly (7)
 - 23 Relaxed in food shop in retreat, cuddling date (5)
 - 24 Look at bottom of pump for leak (4)

- Across
- 1 Where one sees the letter E explicitly? (2,2,4,5)
 - 8 Advance to save boy in valley (5)
 - 9 Delighted with production of oil by American plant (9)
 - 11 Teen in inn excited about boy finally giving number (6-4)
 - 12 Starts to appreciate fine African rhino from a distance (4)
 - 14 Rose edited series about Greek mythological character (7)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Rama's justification

Dharma is sukshma, its subtle meanings difficult to grasp. We should follow what our Acharyas advise us to follow, said Navalpakkam Vasudevachariar in a discourse. Only those who practise dharma must talk about it. Rama was qualified to talk about dharma, because He was a practitioner of dharma. Vaali questions the propriety of Rama's action of shooting an arrow at him (Vaali) from behind, and wonders if His act is dharmic. Rama explains what dharma is to Vaali. Vaali's foremost sin is misbehaviour towards Sugreeva's wife. Vaali is the elder brother of Sugreeva and is therefore like a father to him. He should have treated Sugreeva as he would his son. Would it be right for a man to make his son's wife his own? Vaali, by his conduct towards Sugreeva's wife, had committed a very grave sin. Just as one must not have lustful thoughts about one's daughter or sister, likewise one must not have such thoughts about one's brother's wife.

Having broken such a fundamental rule, how could Vaali talk about dharma and hope for clemency? Dharma sastras say that a king who metes out proper punishment for a crime or a sin will enter heaven. If a thief or a sinner is punished by his king, he escapes hell. But a king who fails to punish a wrongdoer will definitely go to hell, according to the dharma sastras. As for killing Vaali from behind, do hunters have to face animals before killing them, asks Rama. Vaali has been claiming that what he did was right according to vanara dharma. If he took refuge behind the argument that he was an animal, then using the same argument, Rama could say He was justified in hitting Vaali from behind.

Fine print:
Barely read
and rarely
understood

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

In one of the recent pieces on this page, I had emphasised that we must read and understand the insurance policy we are buying. Because once bought, the wording of the contract is binding. I got quite a few responses to that and the preceding pieces, all focusing on the effort needed to understand your policy.

One of them, from a smart neighbour, said, “Good points, Nitya. But for ordinary people there is so much fine print that it is boring. The language is confusing. If we get the non-negotiables as bullet points, it will be very easy to just see that those conditions are met and we can sign.”

She was so right, and yet wrong. They are all there. If we read them – labour over them, actually – we would probably piece together the broad picture. But understanding? That’s a different animal.

The information is all there. Lots of it, in fact. But its presence doesn’t equal comprehension.

What exactly do we mean by “understanding” a policy?

It is not recognising the words, though you will find quite a few that are centuries old.

It is not managing to finish the document, though that’s an achievement in itself. Why? The simplest policy is 12 pages long. And those are fine-print-in-9-point-font-and-double-column-format pages. I have even seen policies printed in blue font. Pretty but pointless.

It is not even being able to repeat what a clause says. I should be able to tell what it means for me, in a real situation, when I have a claim, for example.

I tried this in a formal setting. I gave a couple of bright ladies a hospitalisation policy document, asked them to read through it. One of them immediately asked, “Is this the Constitution?”

I must have looked confused so she pointed to the first paragraph of the document, “it says ‘Preamble’ she said. I peeked over to see what was on her page. It read, “This policy is a contract of insurance issued by XYZ Insurance Company Limited (hereinafter called the ‘Company’) to the proposer mentioned in the schedule (hereinafter called the ‘Insured’) to cover the person(s) named in the schedule (hereinafter called the ‘Insured Persons’)”.

Her next comment I could not but agree with. “Why do I need this?” she asked, genuinely puzzled. Why indeed.

Non-starter

If she had said she did not want to continue further, I would have understood perfectly. In fact, it happened with another person. Peering seriously for a few minutes at the blue-printed document she laid it down emphatically and said, “No, Nitya, I can’t do this.”

Forget reading it or discovering that insurance policies also have preambles, she just couldn’t physically read it. And this a self-taught veteran who handles property and stock market investments by herself.

There were other comments to come. When asked for first impressions on reading through a page or two, a gentleman remarked that it was written defensively, as if they rushing to make clear what they would not do.

Providing 40 pages of information does not necessarily mean the reader will understand it.

I will take you through the rocky path of trying to understand actual insurance policies in future installments of CoverNote.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history.)



Mutual funds exhibited a tight clustering around consistency, while PMS strategies displayed a wide, fat-tail dispersion at both ends of the spectrum. ILLUSTRATION: B. SAINATH

A data-driven analysis
of mutual funds vs. PMS

Across a entire 10-year period, mutual funds delivered an average return of 14.5% CAGR, outperforming the PMS average of 14.0% CAGR by 50 bps, ICRA and PMS Bazaar data show

WHITHER WEALTH

Rushabh Desai

In the Indian wealth management landscape, portfolio management services (PMS) are frequently positioned as a premium upgrade over equity mutual funds. Targeted at high-net-worth individuals (HNIs), PMS strategies theoretically promise bespoke strategy execution, unconstrained stock selection, and superior alpha generation. However, empirical market data evaluating returns over the long term reveals a more nuanced reality: higher entry tickets and concentrated strategies do not automatically translate to superior performance.

An analysis of 10-year annualised return distributions across 79 equity mutual funds (Regular Growth) and 73 equity PMS schemes spanning the Flexi Cap, Large & Mid Cap, Multi Cap, Mid Cap, and Small Cap categories provides critical data on how these two investment structures have actually performed over a decade.

According to data from ICRA and PMS Bazaar, as of August 31, 2026, equity mutual funds generated a higher 10-year average return compared with equity PMS strategies. Across the entire 10-year period, mutual funds delivered an average return of 14.5% CAGR, outperforming the PMS average of 14.0%



Mutual funds exhibited a tight clustering around consistency, whereas PMS strategies displayed a wide, fat-tail dispersion at both ends of the spectrum

CAGR by 50 basis points. While the gap may appear modest on paper, it suggests that the higher ticket size and the higher risk taken in PMS strategies are not necessarily justified by the baseline returns. However, the average is the least interesting metric here; the real story lies in the return distribution between the two structures.

Mutual funds exhibited a tight clustering around consistency, whereas PMS strategies displayed a wide, fat-tail dispersion at both ends of the spectrum. A decent 12% of PMS strategies failed to cross the 10% CAGR mark over 10 years.

In contrast, only 1% of mutual funds fell into this underperforming bracket. An investor choosing a random equity PMS strategy faced a 1-in-8 probability of delivering returns below target long-term risk-free rates plus inflation, whereas the regulatory diversification of mutual funds effectively insulated 99% of schemes above this threshold. An overwhelming majority of mutual funds (98% of all schemes) delivered solid wealth compounding



A decent 12% of PMS strategies failed to cross the 10% CAGR mark over 10 years. In contrast, only 1% of MFs fell into this underperforming bracket

between 10% and 20% CAGR (62% in the 10-15% bucket and 36% in the 15-20% bucket). In comparison, PMS strategies achieved a combined 84% in this range (51% in the 10-15% bucket and 33% in the 15-20% bucket). Ultimately, mutual funds demonstrated far higher consistency in hitting the median market growth corridor.

True advantage

However, PMS demonstrated its true structural advantage at the extreme top end of performance. Approximately 4% of PMS strategies generated blowout returns exceeding 20% CAGR over 10 years, compared to just 1% of mutual funds.

For investors seeking exceptional alpha generation, PMS offered a 4x higher probability of identifying top-decile outlier managers, though the absolute odds of landing there were still just 4 in 100. Understanding why these distributions diverge requires examining the regulatory frameworks and portfolio construction mechanics of both structures:

PMS portfolios typically hold concentrated bets. When top convictions pay off, PMS strategies can hit multi-bagger trajectories. Conversely, when core bets underperform, the lack of diversification leads to a severe long-term return drag.

Equity mutual funds operate under strict categorical mandates. PMS managers, on the other hand, possess near-total flexibility to move across cash, market-cap segments, and sectoral themes. While advantageous, this unconstrained tactical allocation increases the risk of human error, widening the performance dispersion.

PMS offerings frequently incorporate performance fees, management fees, and transaction charges that create higher hurdles for generating net alpha. Additionally, portfolio rebalancing in a PMS incurs direct capital gains tax events for the individual account holder, whereas mutual funds rebalance inside the pool tax-free.

None of this means PMS is a poor product; rather, it is a distinctly different structure that performs in cycles. Success requires thorough due diligence and selecting the right fund manager capable of capturing top-quartile concentrated upside over the medium to long term. In PMS strategies, poor manager selection can result in severe capital drag.

(The writer is Founder - Rupee With Rushabh Investment Services)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Axis Bank	8.90 onwards	10,355 onwards	2,071 onwards	Up to 2%
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.50	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 4.13%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.75	10,550-12,093	2,110-2,419	0.25% (Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,500)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
HSBC Bank	9.70 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 1%
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Poonawalla Fincorp	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 4%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.65-13.90	10,538-11,608	2,108-2,322	0.50%-1%
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 49
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	Up to 0.25%
Canara Bank**	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Central Bank of India	7.50-9.30	10,019 - 10,452	NIL (Till 31.12.2026)
Federal Bank	7.90-9.00	10,114 onwards	1% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 50,000)
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
IDFC FIRST Bank	8.99 onwards	10,377 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Indian Bank	7.55-9.65	10,031 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
Karnataka Bank	8.13-11.63	10,169 - 11,029	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank***	7.55-14.05	10,031 - 11,647	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
State Bank of India	8.30 - 9.35	10,307 - 10,587	Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,000
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000

*0.25% interest rate concession for home loan borrowers/customers with 6 months of relationship with bank
**50% waiver on processing fee till September 30
***Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on September 23

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Managing
inflation
risk

THINKINVESTOR

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Both working executives and retirees are exposed to inflation risk, but retirees are affected more when price levels increase. In this article, we discuss inflation risk in relation to retirees and explore how they can manage this risk.

Hedging issue

Inflation risk is the likelihood that inflation is greater than expected. You will factor in inflation for determining your terminal wealth for a goal. If you are saving to fund your child’s college education, you will factor in education inflation to arrive at the amount you will need when your child enters college. Similarly, when you determine the amount you need at retirement, you must estimate the general inflation during your post-retirement years.

The risk you are exposed to is the likelihood that actual inflation will be greater than the expected inflation you factored into your retirement portfolio calculation.

Note that we are referring to general inflation that will affect your living expenses, not the health-care inflation.

The latter is typically more than double that of general inflation and can increase even when general inflation is in line with expectation.

If you are nearing retirement and are concerned about inflation risk, how should you manage the risk?

A hedge typically works when the investment product value rises in line with the increase in price level. Actual inflation can be greater than expected inflation because of rising commodity prices, especially crude oil.

So, you can buy investment products that take exposure to such commodities to hedge inflation risk. But products for the mass-affluent to hedge inflation risk are unavailable in India. Note that gold and equity investments may not be a good hedge against inflation.

Conclusion

Commodities futures typically offer a good hedge against inflation but have high downside risk and may be unsuitable for mass-affluent retirees. An alternative is rental property. Rental income may not be a hedge against inflation, but rentals can continually increase.

It is optimal to buy a new property just before retirement to earn market rentals. Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) are an affordable alternative for those who do not want to invest lump-sum amount from their retirement corpus into rental properties. REITs are like mutual funds that invest in commercial properties to earn lease rentals.

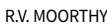
As per SEBI regulation, REITs are required to distribute 90% of their net distributable income (lease rentals minus operating expenses) to their investors every year.

This provides for stable cash flows that could increase with inflation.

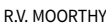
(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in. The experts on personal finance will answer select queries. Moneywise will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular.

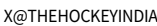
Ancy vows to come back strong after missing out on top spot



Sivasangari was incredible, I couldn't do much, says Anahat



Indian women's hockey team to play Korea in the semifinals



Kohli second after Tendulkar to score 15,000 ODI runs



Ancy misses gold by a whisker; Sarvesh brings home silver

Anahat, Abhay come up short

CM
YK

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

There was a moment in the second half of the Asian Games kabaddi gold-medal match against Iran when Aslam Inamdar made a daring raid deep into the opposition half.

His teammate Pawan Sehrawat groaned inwardly as he did so. India's lead was narrow. Iran was still in the contest. It was a risk that could have gone badly wrong. "It was a bad decision," Pawan would say later. But Inamdar made the dash count, securing two touches and emerging unscathed. The points brought India closer to victory. "It was a wrong move, but *ant bhala toh sab bhala* (if the end is good, it's all worth it)," Inamdar said after the match.

He grinned when he recalled the sequence later. It had been a tough decision to make. Wasn't he worried when he made that move? What would have happened if it had gone wrong? "*Bhai*, I've gone through things you wouldn't even imagine. This is nothing," he said.

That, in many ways, is the story of Aslam Inamdar.

There was a time when, as a 14-year-old, he travelled across Maharashtra in search of kabaddi tournaments without even having enough money for a train ticket. He slept under train seats, survived on stale vada pav or whatever food was available at tournaments. He sometimes stuffed leftover food which often spilled into his bag. "If there was work to be done, I did it. I've cleaned toilets. I've sold juice and made tea. I've worked in fields. If there was a kabaddi tournament to play, I found a way to get there."

In Nagoya on Saturday, Inamdar stood on the mat as India beat Iran to win the men's kabaddi gold. It is his second Asian Games gold medal. The distance between those two versions of Inamdar is difficult even for him to comprehend.

"It still feels like a dream to me," he said. "I often think about how someone who didn't even have food at home holds two international medals."

The medals are the latest chapter in a journey that began at Takli Bhan in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district, where Inamdar grew up as one of five children.

His father passed away when he was young, leaving his mother to raise the family. She worked in other homes, doing household chores and washing utensils, to keep the family going. Later, his elder brother Waseem joined the police force and took responsibility, including helping arrange the marriages of their two sisters.

Money was scarce. Inamdar remembers growing up in a house without proper flooring or roof. There were times when even food was difficult to come by.

So, he learnt early that work meant survival. At 11 or 12, he collected



discarded bottles and sold them to scrap dealers to buy food. Later, he worked at tea stalls and juice bars, washed utensils, cleaned washrooms and worked in farm fields. He admits he stole sometimes. "It was just to fill my stomach. I faced many hard situations without letting them break me," he said.

Through all of it, there was one constant: kabaddi. Waseem was a well-known player across several districts while senior player Rahul Bhor also inspired him. Inamdar wanted to establish his own identity. "No matter how long I worked during the day or night, I always went to the ground to train," the raider said.

Kabaddi was a sport he could afford. It required little equipment, and the village ground was enough. For a boy with very little money, it offered something priceless: a chance. By the time he was 14 or 15, Inamdar was travelling alone to tournaments to compete in the 50kg and 55kg categories. He earned between ₹200

From cleaning rest rooms to winning two Asian Games golds – the rise of Aslam Inamdar

The star raider has cleared many hurdles and come a long way since taking to kabaddi when he was about 14; irrespective of the hardships, the sport has been a constant



and ₹500 a match. The money was little, but it mattered. It bought him meals when he might otherwise have gone hungry. More importantly, it kept him moving from one tournament to the next. The path was neither smooth nor uninterrupted. In 2014, while India competed at the Asian Games, Inamdar was at

home nursing a fractured leg and following kabaddi on television. His life at the time seemed a world away from an international career. "I was just watching kabaddi on TV. But I believe God's plans are always better. My hard work never stopped."

He kept working. Eventually, the Pro Kabaddi League changed the scale of his life.

In his first season, he earned ₹8 lakh. For someone who had once struggled to put food on the table, the money was almost incomprehensible. "Eight lakh felt like eight crore to me," he said.

He did not forget where he had come from. With his first major earnings, he bought a gold necklace for his mother. Kabaddi had given him something that had once seemed almost impossible: financial security, recognition and a career. He went on to captain Puneri Paltan and establish himself as one of India's leading players. Then came the international medals.

Inamdar won his first Asian Games gold in Hangzhou. Three years later in Nagoya, he has another. And once again, the final was against Iran – the one opponent which has consistently pushed India hardest at the Asian Games. "Iran is generally the most challenging opponent for us," Inamdar said. "It has a strong defence and has very experienced players like Fazel Atrachali, who played in his fifth Asian Games."

For Inamdar, beating such a formidable opponent made the gold more meaningful. "A tough challenge makes winning the gold medal feel even more rewarding."

But for Inamdar, the significance of the medal lies beyond the result. It is the culmination of a journey that began when he was a boy travelling across Maharashtra for a few hundred rupees, when he collected scrap bottles for food and worked whatever jobs he could find before heading to the kabaddi ground.

Today, he tries to pass on that experience to younger players. At his training ground in Thane, he speaks to juniors, particularly those from underprivileged backgrounds, about his own journey. He wants them to understand that difficult circumstances do not have to determine where they end up. "I want young, underprivileged players to dream big and aim to achieve even more than I have. I want them to know that whatever happens, they shouldn't stop working hard. They shouldn't stop believing," he said.



It still feels like a dream to me. I often think about how someone who didn't even have food at home holds two international medals



Iran is generally the most challenging opponent. It has a strong defence and has experienced players like Fazel Atrachali

THE GIST

The medals are the latest chapter in a journey that began at Takli Bhan in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district, where Inamdar grew up as one of five children

He clinched both his gold medals after defeating Iran in finals

The raider wants the next generation to understand that difficult circumstances do not have to determine where they end up

COP31 hosts Australia and Türkiye face the fossil-fuel question

There is likely to be pressure on the COP31 presidencies to include fossil fuel language as part of the agenda. The catastrophic floods in Nepal on August 26 and the damage they wrought are also set to add momentum to both mitigation action, including the language surrounding fossil fuels at COP31

Rishika Pardikar
TRABZON, TÜRKİYE

The next United Nations climate change conference, COP31, will be held in Antalya in Türkiye in November this year. Türkiye will be hosting the event, with its Minister of Environment Murat Kurum serving as COP31 President. Australia will oversee the negotiations process, with its Minister for Climate Change and Energy Chris Bowen as the Vice-President of COP31.

This is a novel arrangement – a result of both Australia and Türkiye not being willing to concede their demand to host, and where both countries share crucial responsibilities. In previous editions, the COP’s physical host has differed from the President only for logistical reasons.

A pre-COP event will be held in Fiji on October 5-8, where Pacific Island countries and Australia will discuss preparations for the main event, including what to negotiate. These pre-COPs are a routine affair before the annual summits.

Domestic fossil reliance

Both Türkiye and Australia are heavy users of fossil fuels. Australia is the world’s third-largest fossil fuels exporter, after Russia and the U.S. Domestically, Australia as well as Türkiye rely on coal, gas, and oil to generate respectively around 90% and 80% of their energy needs. Three weeks ago, Australia also came under fire from climate groups for approving the expansion of a coal mine.

The primary goal at COP31 is a target to electrify industry and vehicles and in turn “to raise the share of final energy demand met by electricity from just over 20% today to 35% by 2035”.

‘Oceans and Seas’ are also a priority agenda: Türkiye hosted a ‘Blue Dialogue’ on September 10-11 whose focus was on protecting marine resources.

However, none of the themes listed as a priority for the event make direct reference to transitioning away from fossil fuels.

That said, various industries in Australia, including iron-ore mining, are trying to decarbonise by investing in hybrid or electric heavy machinery. Local governments are also pushing for electric vehicles (EVs), which recently overtook petrol car sales for the first time in Australia.

Türkiye, on the other hand, is working to augment recycling and so eventually reduce methane emissions. In fact, the country has listed ‘zero waste and a circular economy’ on the COP31 priority list. The fortunes of a local EV brand,



An oil rig is visible in the distance near Cape Town harbour. ALPHA PERSPECTIVE/UNSPASH

Togg, has ballooned so much that the government hopes it will herald a new era in the automobiles market.

Loss and damage financing

At the COP30 in Belém, Brazil, last year, the European Union pushed for a “fossil fuel roadmap” to help countries worldwide transition away from fossil fuels. While many countries supported the call, observers have said it took the focus away from developing countries’ calls to triple adaptation finance and developed countries’ resistance to that.

That said, most countries involved in the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) did not oppose the call for the “fossil fuel road map” at COP30.

India did not oppose either, on the condition that it incorporate the principle of common but differentiated responsibilities and that countries are not expected to follow uniform energy transition pathways. Beyond the UNFCCC framework as well, and partly because of the slow pace of negotiations at the COP summits, there have been calls for concrete action to transition away from fossil fuels. In April this year, the first conference on “Transitioning Away from Fossil Fuels” was held in Santa Marta in Colombia, co-hosted by Colombia and the Netherlands.

The second conference is scheduled

for 2027, to be co-hosted by Tuvalu and Ireland.

Given such momentum, there is likely to be pressure on the COP31 Presidencies to include fossil fuel language as part of the agenda. The catastrophic floods in Nepal on August 26, boosted no doubt by climate change, and the damage they wrought are also set to add momentum to both mitigation action, including the language surrounding fossil fuels at COP31, and to loss and damage financing. But as with their not mentioning the transition away from fossil fuels, the joint Australia-Türkiye presidents have also included no loss and damage financing, or even the broader climate finance question, among the priority topics.

“We know there are strong views on all sides of this topic,” the Türkiye Presidency said in response to questions from the author about whether this will change. “We will create space for Parties to discuss the transition and listen carefully to the positions they bring forward to see what we can agree by consensus. But listening to Parties’ views on negotiations does not mean we are standing still. We are taking the next logical steps in the energy transition by making electrification the flagship thematic priority of the COP31 Presidency’s Action Agenda, because electrifying buildings, transport and industry is key to reducing emissions and

should be accompanied by complementary efforts to expand renewable energy.

Likewise, the reply said on mitigation financing: “we have been clear that we need to close the climate finance chasm, and we are holding donors to the financial commitments made at past COPs, while also introducing innovative new mechanisms, such as the ‘Climate Implementation Bridge’, to address the gap between ambitious climate plans and the finance needed to make them a reality.”

The Australian Presidency did not respond.

Countries participating at COPs can propose new agenda items for consideration during negotiations. For example, the European Union introduced the “road map” in the formal negotiations agenda at the last minute at COP30. That said, it remains to be seen whether countries will do so at COP31, and if so what the items will be – and ultimately how the event’s two fossil fuel-heavy stewards will navigate negotiations.

The author was in Türkiye September 8-13 at the invitation of the government for a COP31-themed media tour. She also visited Australia in October 2025 on a similar official tour.

(Rishika Pardikar is a freelance journalist. rishika.s.pardikar@gmail.com)

THE GIST

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Australia and Türkiye are heavy users of fossil fuels; both countries rely on coal, gas, and oil to generate respectively around 90% and 80% of their domestic energy needs; Australia is the world’s third-largest fossil fuels exporter

▼

The primary goal at COP31 is a target to electrify industry and vehicles and in turn ‘to raise the share of final energy demand met by electricity from just over 20% today to 35% by 2035’; ‘Oceans and Seas’ are also a priority agenda

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At COP30, the EU advocated a global ‘fossil fuel roadmap’ to guide the transition away from fossil fuels; critics said it diverted attention from developing nations’ demand for tripling adaptation finance

BIG SHOT



Coastal fury: Waves caused by Hurricane Polo seen battering a small island with houses off the coast of San Blas in Mexico on September 26; It moved away from Mexico’s Pacific coast on Saturday as a Category 4 storm and is expected to return to make landfall in Baja California Sur on Monday, forecasters said. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

UN Sea Level Declaration

Vasudevan Mukunth

On September 24, the United Nations General Assembly approved the Declaration on Sea Level Rise by consensus.

Perhaps its most important provision concerns international law. The Declaration affirms that low-lying countries especially threatened by rising seas, such as Fiji, Tuvalu, and Vanuatu, will continue to retain their statehood, sovereign rights, and UN membership. It also says maritime zones will continue to be defined in line with the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea, even if rising waters cause coastlines to retreat further inland.

The Declaration arose from a high-level meeting in 2024 and which member countries had since negotiated under a mandate calling for an action-oriented agreement. Spanning four pages, the Declaration organises action around (i) science and data, (ii) adaptation and financing, (iii) livelihoods, socio-economic development, data-sharing, and early-warnings, and (iv) the legal consequences of sea-level rise.

It also calls on countries to respond to sea-level rise in a way that addresses livelihoods and cultural heritage and with the involvement of affected communities.

The world’s low-lying island states — which have organised themselves as the Alliance of Small Island States in international fora, including the COP



The current global mean sea-level rise is 4-5 mm/year. LOOK UP LOOK DOWN
PHOTOGRAPHY/UNSPASH

climate talks — need these assurances because the seas surrounding them threaten to swallow most or all of their habitable territory in the coming decades. If they do, the Declaration will ensure their citizens continue to retain their nationality and economic rights.

The pact also commits UN member countries to continue to engage on issues related to sea-level rise, including a high-level meeting before the 84th session of the General Assembly ends.

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